SAVMUN

ST. DOMINIC SAVIO HIGH SCHOOL

BACKGROUNDGUIDE | UNEP

LETTERS TO DELEGATES
FROM THE CHAIR

Dear Delegates,

Welcome to the United Nations Environment Programme! My name is [Your Name], and I am so excited to be your chair for this session.

Have you ever been to the beach and seen a plastic bottle floating in the waves or a snack wrapper buried in the sand? It might seem like a small thing, but when millions of people do the same, it creates a global crisis. Today, we are here to talk about how we can stop plastic from entering our oceans and protect the animals from tiny fish to giant whales that call the sea their home.

As delegates, you will need to think like scientists and leaders. How can we change the way we use plastic? How can we clean up what is already there? I look forward to hearing your creative ideas on how to #BeatPlasticPollution!

Image of Chair

Best wishes,

[Your Name,] Chair

INTRODUCTION

The UNEP is the voice for the environment within the United Nations. Our job is to help countries take care of the air, land, and water.

One of our biggest challenges is Marine Litter. This is any man made solid material that ends up in the ocean. About 19 to 23 million tonnes of plastic leak into our lakes, rivers, and seas every single year. Because the ocean connects us all, plastic from one country can wash up on the shores of another thousands of miles away. This is why we must work together as a global community.

TOPIC:

Reducing Plastic Pollution in Coastal and Marine Ecosystems

STATEMENT OF THE PROBLEM

Plastic is a forever material, it doesn't go away; it just breaks into smaller and smaller pieces called microplastics. This causes three major problems:

- Harming Wildlife: Sea turtles often mistake plastic bags for jellyfish (their favorite food), and birds can get tangled in discarded fishing nets.
- Human Health: When small fish eat microplastics, those plastics move up the food chain, Eventually, they can end up in the food humans eat.
- Economic Loss: Coastal towns that rely on tourism lose money when their beaches are covered in trash. It also costs billions of dollars to clean up harbors and fix boat engines damaged by gloating debris.

HISTORY OF THE PROBLEM

- The Rise of Plastic: Since the 1950s, the world has produced over 9 billion tonnes of plastic. Most of it was designed to be used once and then thrown away.
- SDG 14 (Life Below Water): In 2015, the UN set a goal to significantly reduce marine pollution of all kinds by the year 2025.
- The Global Treaty (2022-2024): Right now, countries are meeting to write a Global Plastic Treaty. This would be a legally binding law that requires every country to reduce plastic waste.

CURRENT SITUATION

The UNEP is leading the Clean Seas campaign to flip the tide on plastic.

- Circular Economy: Instead of Take, Make, Dispose, the UNEP wants a circular system where we design products to be reused or recycled instead of becoming trash.
- Ban on Single Use Plastics: Many countries, like Kenya and Canada, have already started banning plastic bags and straws.
- Upstream Solutions: We are focusing on upstream fixes, meaning we stop the plastic at the factory before it even reaches the consumer.

QUESTIONS TO CONSIDER

- What are some alternatives to plastic that your country could use (like bamboo, paper, or glass)?
- How can we help small island nations (like Fiji or the Maldives) deal with trash that washes up on their beaches from other countries?
- Should companies be responsible for paying to clean up the plastic they produce?
- How can we teach students and families in your country to reduce their plastic footprint?

LIST OF COUNTRIES (DELEGATION)

The Americas:
United States
Canada
Mexico
Costa Rica
Brazil

Africa:
Kenya
Nigeria
South Africa
Egypt
Seychelles

Oceania and Island Nations:
Philippines
Australia
Fiji
Maldives

Europe:
United Kingdom
France
Norway
Greece
Germany

Asia and the Middle East
China
Indonesia
Vietnam
Thailand
India
Japan

KEY TERMS

- Marine Litter: Any persistent, manufactured, or processed solid material discarded in the marine and coastal environment.
- Microplastics: Tiny plastic particles (less than 5mm long) that are harmful to aquatic life.
- Single Use Plastic: Plastic items intended to be used only once before they are thrown away, like straws or coffee stirrers.
- Circular Economy: A system where products are designed to be reused and kept in the economy rather than becoming waste.
- Ghost Gear: Abandoned or lost fishing equipment (like nets) that countries use to trap and kill marine life.

WORK CITED & RESEARCH FOR STUDENTS:

- UNEP Interactive Plastic Story: https://www.unep.org/interactives/beat-plastic-pollution/ (A great visual guide to the problem).
- National Geographic Kids - Plastic Pollution: https://kids.nationalgeographic.com/ (Easy to read articles on how plastic affects animals).
- The Global Partnership on Plastic Pollution (GPML): https://www.gpmarinelitter.org/ (Data on where ocean plastics come from).
- UN Ocean Conference Resources: https://sdgs.un.org/goals/goal14 (Details on the Life Below Water goals).